

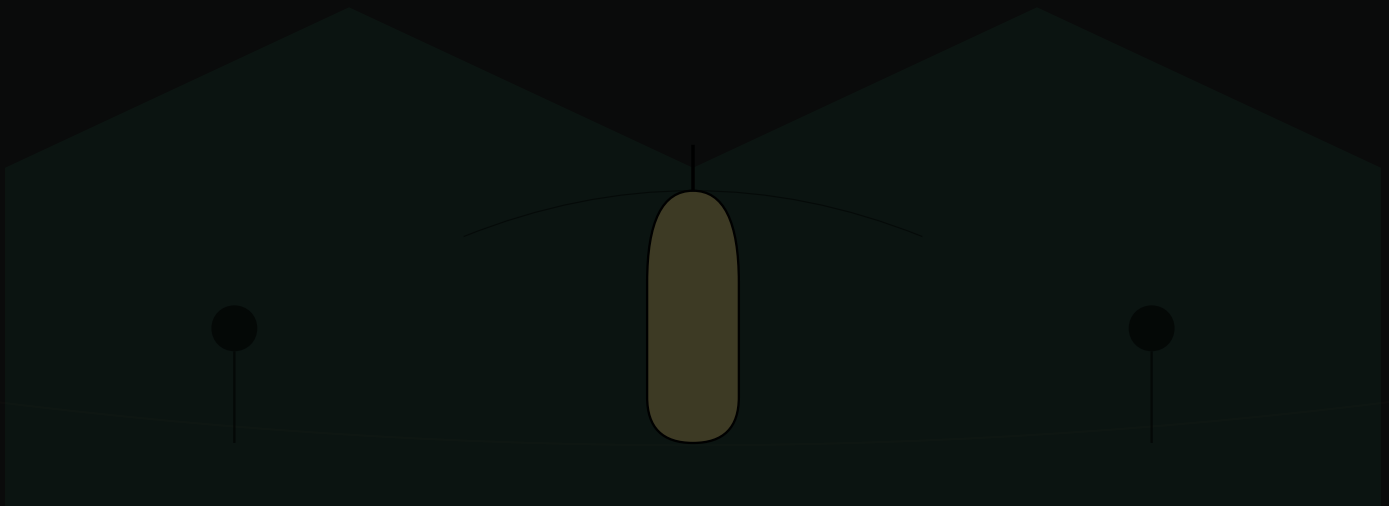
ORAKZAI MUSIC

“When a people sings, memory finds a voice.”

Music can preserve a place long after the sound itself has faded. A song can remember a mountain. A verse can remember a harvest. A melody can remember a wedding. A woman's voice can carry a memory that was never written down. An elder can remember a song that younger generations have never heard. For the Orakzai, music exists within the larger world of Pashto language and Pashtun culture, but it also contains local memories. Songs documented as Orakzai folk songs speak of love, separation, weddings, harvests, weather, mountains, travel and everyday life. They show something important about cultural memory: A people does not preserve its history only through books. Sometimes it preserves history through melody.

MELODY OF THE VALLEY

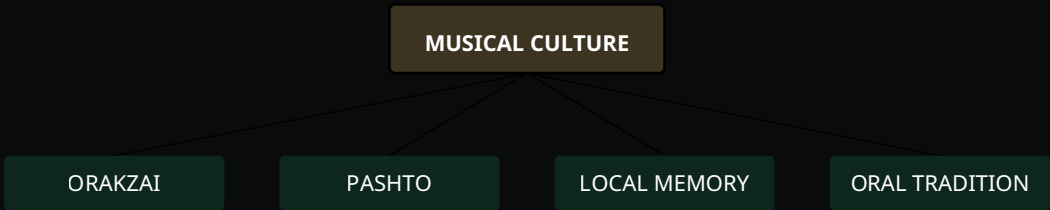
“Preserving History through Voice and Verse”



“The musical landscape: where Rubab, voice, and mountain memory converge.”

WHAT IS ORAKZAI MUSIC?

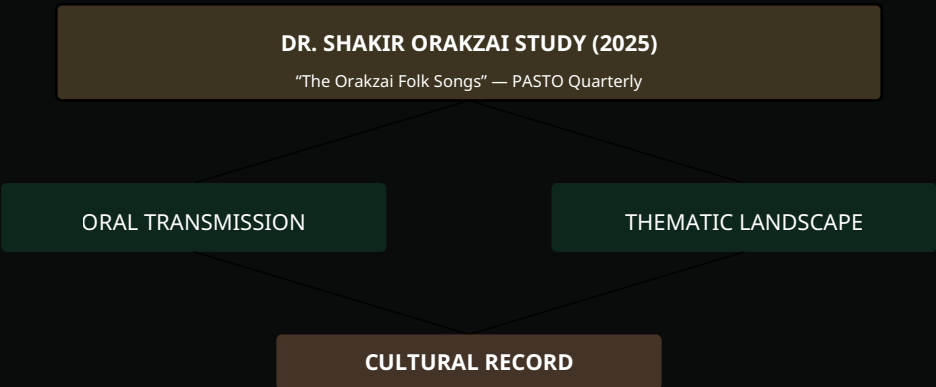
“Orakzai music” should be understood as music documented among Orakzai communities rather than as a completely separate musical system isolated from wider Pashto traditions. It is the intersection of broad Pashtun musical forms and local Orakzai memories preserved through oral tradition.



“The synthesis of Orakzai musical identity.”

A DIRECT RECORD: THE ORAKZAI FOLK SONGS STUDY (2025)

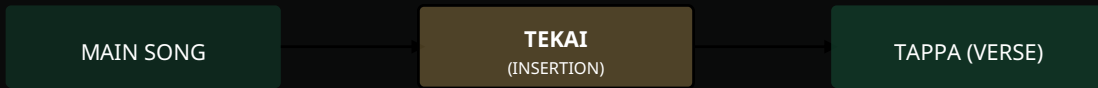
A major contribution to the documentation of Orakzai music is the 2025 study by **Dr. Shakir “Orakzai”** published in the *PASTO Quarterly*. The study identifies a body of folk songs associated with Orakzai communities, exploring their themes, structures, and methods of oral transmission. It provides a direct record of songs remembered by elders and transmitted through generations.¹



“Methodological focus of the 2025 Orakzai folk-song study.”

TEKAI: AN ORAKZAI-SPECIFIC STRUCTURE

The study documents a specific structural element in Orakzai folk songs known as ****Tekai****. Many Orakzai folk songs are structured so that ****Tappas**** (traditional folk verses) can be inserted between sections. These inserted verses, identified as Tekai, allow for the interaction of established melody and spontaneous poetic expression.¹



“The structural integration of Tekai and Tappa in Orakzai songs.”

SAIL: WOMEN’S FESTIVE GATHERINGS

The Orakzai folk-song study records a festive gathering of village women known as ****Sail****. On Eid nights, young women would gather near springs or particular trees to play, sing, and recite folk verses. These gatherings provided a space for emotional and social expression through melody and frolic.¹

SAIL: THE FESTIVE GATHERING



“The social and emotional components of the Sail gathering.”

LANDSCAPE & AGRICULTURE IN SONG

Documented Orakzai folk songs are deeply connected to the local landscape and agricultural cycles. Songs refer to places like **Tirah** and **Daburi**, and describe seasonal weather such as snow and rain. Notably, the study records a folk song about the **wheat harvest**, showing that work was not merely economic activity but entered the local musical expression.¹

LANDSCAPE IN SONG

TIRAH / DABURI

MOUNTAINS / SPRINGS

SNOW / RAIN

MUSICAL MEMORY

“Geographic references as cultural memory.”

HARVEST SONGS

WHEAT HARVEST

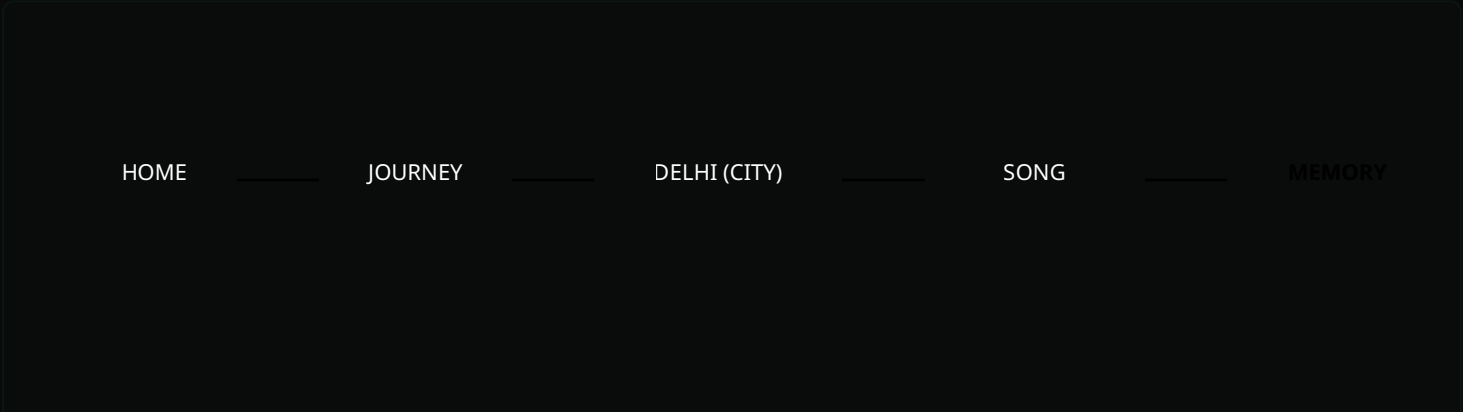
WORK & MELODY

HOUSEHOLD MEMORY

“The link between agricultural labor and musical expression.”

MIGRATION: THE MEMORY OF DELHI

Migration also leaves its mark on folk music. The Orakzai folk-song study discusses a song referring to **Delhi**, interpreted as memory of historical Pashtun travel for livelihoods. This shows how distant journeys and cities become part of the portable cultural memory of a people.¹



“The pathway of migration memory in folk song.”

PASHTO MUSIC: THE WIDER WORLD

While Orakzai songs contain local memories, they exist within the broader Pashtun musical tradition. This tradition includes various poetic and song forms, each with its own social and ceremonial role.²



“Major forms of Pashto folk music.”

MUSICAL ELEMENT	ORAKZAI-SPECIFIC	PASHTUN-WIDE	REGIONAL	EVIDENCE
Tekai (Structure)	Documented ORAKZAI	-	-	Orakzai (2025) [1]
Sail (Gathering)	Documented ORAKZAI	-	-	Orakzai (2025) [1]
Tappa (Verse)	Common Practice	Standard PASHTUN	Universal	AIPS [2]
Rubab (Instrument)	Common Practice	Standard PASHTUN	Regional KP	AIPS [2]
Spring Mela Concerts	Documented MODERN	-	-	Radio Pakistan (2024) [3]

The **Rubab** is the most iconic instrument associated with Pashto music, serving as the soulful accompaniment to folk verses. Other traditional instruments include the **Mangay** (clay pot percussion) and **Zerbaghali**. In modern times, the harmonium, tabla, and electronic production have become part of the contemporary Orakzai musical landscape.²³



CONTEMPORARY EVENT EVIDENCE: The 2024 Orakzai Spring Mela included music concerts as part of a modern festival program. This demonstrates contemporary public musical activity in Orakzai but should not be treated as evidence of an ancient tribal festival-music tradition.

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

Music is a form of survival. When a people has faced displacement and silence, a song becomes a way to claim a space in the world. For the Orakzai, folk songs are not just entertainment; they are the vessels of memory. A Tappa recited at a wedding or a Tekai inserted into a harvest song connects the individual to the land and the tribe. Traditions evolve—modern instruments replace older ones, and digital archives replace oral repetition—but the human need to sing our history remains unchanged. As long as the melody continues, the memory of the valley will never be lost.

"SOMETIMES HISTORY IS PRESERVED THROUGH MELODY."

